



HEALTH PROFESSIONS ADVISING

DENTAL SCHOOL HANDBOOK

Purpose of This Handbook

Choosing to pursue a career in dentistry is an exciting and deeply personal decision. Whether you have been interested in the profession for years or are just beginning to explore it, preparing for dental school requires thoughtful academic planning, meaningful experiences, self-reflection, and a commitment to developing the knowledge, skills, and personal qualities expected of future oral healthcare professionals.

This handbook was developed by Villanova University's Health Professions Advising (HPA) Program to help you navigate each stage of the pre-dental journey – from exploring dentistry as a career to successfully applying to dental school. It provides practical guidance grounded in current admissions practices while encouraging you to make informed decisions that align with your interests, strengths, and long-term goals.

This handbook is intended to help you understand the academic preparation, experiences, and application components important for dental school admission and how they contribute to your development as a future clinician. Throughout these pages, you will find information on academic preparation, the Dental Admission Test (DAT), building meaningful clinical and service experiences, developing manual dexterity and professionalism, preparing a competitive application, and utilizing the resources available through Villanova and the broader pre-dental community.

Because admissions requirements and expectations vary among dental schools, use this handbook alongside individual school admissions websites and regular meetings with HPA as you prepare to apply.

Connect with Health Professions Advising

Schedule an Appointment in Handshake

Whether you're exploring dentistry for the first time or preparing to apply, Health Professions Advising is here to support you.

We encourage students to schedule an appointment early and visit us often throughout their undergraduate journey.

Meet with HPA to discuss:

- Dental school prerequisites and how they fit within your academic plan
- Exploring dentistry and assessing career fit
- Clinical, shadowing, service, leadership, and research experiences
- DAT preparation and testing timeline
- Building manual dexterity and professional competencies
- Application strategy, school selection, and the ADEA AADSAS application
- Personal statements, letters of recommendation, and interviews
- Gap years and academic enhancement pathways



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Navigating the Handbook

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Exploring Dentistry as a Career

What is Dentistry?

Dentistry is a healthcare profession dedicated to the prevention, diagnosis, and treatment of conditions affecting the teeth, mouth, jaws, and surrounding oral and maxillofacial structures. While many people associate dentistry primarily with routine cleanings, fillings, or tooth extractions, the profession encompasses a broad range of preventive, restorative, surgical, cosmetic, and rehabilitative care that plays an essential role in overall health and well-being.

Oral health is closely connected to systemic health. Dentists help identify and manage oral diseases and conditions that can affect nutrition, speech, comfort, self-confidence, and quality of life, while also recognizing signs of broader medical conditions that may first present in the oral cavity. Through patient education and preventive care, dentists work to reduce disease before it occurs, helping patients maintain healthy smiles throughout their lives.

Dentistry combines scientific knowledge with technical precision, creativity, and strong interpersonal skills. Every patient presents unique clinical findings, personal goals, and healthcare needs, requiring dentists to integrate evidence-based decision making with excellent communication and meticulous attention to detail. Successful dentists are lifelong learners who continually adapt to advances in technology, materials, and clinical techniques while building trusting relationships with patients and collaborating with other healthcare professionals.

Dentists may practice in a variety of settings, including private practices, group practices, community health centers, hospitals, academic institutions, military service, and public health organizations.

Many students enter college with only a limited understanding of the profession based on their experiences as dental patients. However, practicing dentistry involves far more than performing procedures. It requires critical thinking, precision, compassion, professionalism, ethical decision making, and a genuine commitment to improving the health and well-being of others. As you begin exploring dentistry as a career, it is important to look beyond your experiences in the dental chair and seek opportunities to observe the profession firsthand through shadowing, conversations with practicing dentists, and meaningful engagement within the dental community.

Did You Know?

Dentists complete four years of dental school after earning a bachelor's degree. Those who pursue a specialty complete additional residency training, which typically ranges from two to six years depending on the specialty.

Is Dentistry Right for You?

Choosing a career in dentistry involves much more than enjoying science or wanting to work in healthcare. Dentistry is a profession that combines scientific knowledge, technical precision, artistry, communication, and service. While every dentist brings unique strengths to the profession, there are certain interests, skills, and personal characteristics that often contribute to long-term satisfaction and success.

One of the defining aspects of dentistry is its hands-on nature. Dentists spend much of their day performing procedures that require exceptional attention to detail, fine motor skills, and careful planning. Whether restoring a damaged tooth, creating a treatment plan, or performing a surgical procedure, dentists must be comfortable working with precision in a small and highly visible area. Unlike many healthcare professions, the results of a dentist's work are often immediately apparent to both the patient and the clinician.

Dentistry also offers the opportunity to build meaningful, long-term relationships with patients. Many patients remain with the same dentist for years or even decades, allowing dentists to become trusted healthcare providers within their communities. Successful dentists enjoy educating patients, helping them make informed decisions about their oral health, and creating a welcoming environment for individuals who may experience fear or anxiety about dental care.

At the same time, dentistry can be both physically and mentally demanding. Dentists must maintain concentration during lengthy procedures, communicate effectively with patients and members of the dental team, and continually adapt to advances in technology, materials, and evidence-based practice. Many dentists also balance responsibilities beyond patient care, including leadership, business management, and practice operations.

As you explore the profession, consider not only whether you can become a dentist, but whether the day-to-day work aligns with your interests, values, and strengths. Shadowing practicing dentists, volunteering in dental settings, and speaking with professionals from a variety of practice environments can help you develop a realistic understanding of the profession before committing to the path.

Questions for Reflection

As you explore dentistry, consider the following questions:

- Do you enjoy working with your hands and developing precise technical skills?
- Are you patient and detail-oriented when completing meticulous tasks?
- Do you enjoy building long-term relationships with patients?
- Are you comfortable communicating with individuals from diverse backgrounds, including those who may be anxious or fearful?
- Do you enjoy solving complex problems that require both scientific knowledge and creativity?

- Are you willing to continually learn and adapt as new technologies and treatment approaches emerge?
- Can you remain calm and focused in situations where precision and attention to detail are essential?
- Does the combination of science, artistry, patient care, and problem-solving genuinely excite you?

There are no ‘right’ answers to these questions. Use them to reflect on whether the day-to-day work of dentistry aligns with your interests, strengths, and professional goals.

What Does a Typical Career Look Like?

One of the appealing aspects of dentistry is the variety of career paths available after graduation. While all dentists share the common goal of improving oral health, the setting in which they practice, the patients they serve, and the procedures they perform can vary considerably. Throughout their careers, many dentists also have opportunities to expand their skills, pursue advanced training, assume leadership roles, or transition into teaching, research, administration, or public health.

Most dental school graduates begin their careers as general dentists, providing comprehensive oral healthcare for patients of all ages. General dentists diagnose and treat oral disease, perform restorative procedures, manage preventive care, educate patients, and coordinate treatment with specialists when necessary. They are often the primary oral healthcare provider for individuals and families, developing long-term relationships with patients and emphasizing disease prevention alongside treatment.

Dentists practice in a wide variety of settings. Some join private practices, either as associates or practice owners, while others work in group practices or Dental Service Organizations (DSOs), where administrative responsibilities such as billing, staffing, and marketing may be shared among a larger organization. Others choose careers in community health centers, hospital-based dental clinics, academic institutions, military service, public health agencies, or the Veterans Health Administration, where they may care for underserved populations, teach future dentists, conduct research, or contribute to improving oral health at the community or population level.

Examples of Practice Settings

- Private Practice
- Group Practice or Dental Service Organization (DSO)
- Community Health Center
- Hospital Dentistry
- Academic Dentistry
- Military Dentistry
- Public Health
- Veterans Health Administration
- Research and Industry

A typical workday often includes a combination of patient examinations, preventive care, restorative procedures, treatment planning, emergency visits, and consultations with patients and members of the dental team. While clinical responsibilities occupy much of the day, dentists also devote time to reviewing patient records, discussing treatment options, maintaining documentation, and participating in continuing education to stay current with advances in technology and evidence-based practice.

Dentists who pursue specialty practice complete additional residency training after dental school. The table below provides an overview of recognized specialty pathways.

Although every career path is different, dentistry offers considerable flexibility throughout a professional lifetime. Some dentists remain in the same practice for decades, while others transition between clinical practice, ownership, teaching, research, administration, consulting, or public service as their interests and goals evolve. This flexibility allows many dentists to shape careers that reflect both their professional aspirations and personal priorities.

General Dentistry and Dental Specialties

Specialty	Primary Focus	Typical Additional Training
General Dentistry	Comprehensive oral healthcare, including preventive, restorative, and diagnostic care for patients of all ages.	None beyond dental school
Dental Anesthesiology	Pain management, sedation, and anesthesia for dental procedures, particularly for patients with complex medical needs or dental anxiety.	3 years
Dental Public Health	Improving oral health at the community and population level through prevention, education, policy, and research.	2 years
Endodontics	Diagnosis and treatment of diseases affecting the dental pulp and tissues surrounding the roots of teeth, including root canal therapy.	2–3 years
Oral and Maxillofacial Pathology	Diagnosis and study of diseases affecting the mouth, jaws, and related structures using clinical and laboratory methods.	3 years
Oral and Maxillofacial Radiology	Interpretation of diagnostic imaging used to evaluate diseases and conditions of the oral and facial region.	2–3 years
Oral and Maxillofacial Surgery	Surgical treatment of conditions affecting the mouth, jaws, face, and neck, including facial trauma, corrective jaw surgery, dental	4–6 years

	implants, and wisdom tooth removal.	
Oral Medicine	Diagnosis and non-surgical management of complex oral health conditions, particularly those related to systemic disease.	2–3 years
Orthodontics and Dentofacial Orthopedics	Prevention and correction of malocclusion and alignment of the teeth and jaws using braces, clear aligners, and other appliances.	2–3 years
Pediatric Dentistry	Comprehensive oral healthcare for infants, children, adolescents, and patients with special healthcare needs.	2–3 years
Periodontics	Prevention, diagnosis, and treatment of diseases affecting the gums and supporting structures of the teeth, including dental implants.	3 years
Prosthodontics	Restoration and replacement of missing or damaged teeth using crowns, bridges, dentures, implants, and other prosthetic devices.	3 years

Note: Most dental school graduates enter practice as general dentists. While some students pursue specialty training immediately after dental school, many choose to gain clinical experience as general dentists before applying to residency. Specialty training is competitive and typically requires an additional two to six years of education, depending on the discipline.

Exploring the Profession Before Applying

Meaningful career exploration is an essential part of preparing for dental school. Before committing to the time, financial investment, and responsibility of becoming a dentist, it is important to develop a realistic understanding of the profession. While your experiences as a dental patient may provide some insight, they represent only a small part of what dentists do each day. The best way to determine whether dentistry is the right career for you is to observe the profession firsthand and reflect on what you learn.

Shadowing Dentists

Shadowing provides an opportunity to observe patient care, clinical procedures, communication, and practice operations in a real-world setting. Most dental schools expect applicants to have spent meaningful time observing a general dentist, and many also value exposure to one or more dental specialties.

As you shadow, pay attention not only to the procedures being performed, but also to the interactions between the dentist, patients, hygienists, assistants, and office staff. Consider how the dentist communicates complex information, manages challenging situations, and balances technical precision with compassionate patient care.

Engage Beyond Observation

While shadowing is valuable, consider seeking additional opportunities to engage with the profession. Volunteering in community oral health programs, working as a dental assistant, participating in pre-dental student organizations, attending professional meetings, or conducting informational interviews with practicing dentists can provide broader perspectives on the field.

These experiences allow you to better understand the diverse practice settings, patient populations, and career paths available within dentistry while helping you develop professionally.

Reflect on Your Experiences

The purpose of career exploration is to develop an informed understanding of dentistry and determine whether the profession is a good fit for you. Applicants should be prepared to explain what they have learned from their experiences and why they want to pursue dentistry.

As you gain experience, ask yourself:

- What aspects of dentistry excite me most?
- What challenges did I observe, and how did the dentist respond?
- Can I see myself performing this type of work every day?
- How have these experiences influenced my understanding of the profession?

Taking time to reflect on your experiences will not only help you determine whether dentistry is the right career for you, but will also strengthen your ability to write compelling application essays and discuss your motivation during interviews.

HPA Tip: Begin exploring dentistry early in your undergraduate career. Starting early gives you the opportunity to observe multiple practice settings, build meaningful relationships with mentors, and confirm that the profession aligns with your interests before you apply.

Academic Preparation

Choosing a Major

One of the most common questions students ask is whether they need to major in biology or another science to be admitted to dental school. **The answer is no.** Dental schools accept students from a wide variety of academic backgrounds, and there is no preferred or required undergraduate major for admission.

While many applicants choose majors in the biological or physical sciences because they naturally incorporate many of the prerequisite courses for dental school, successful applicants come from disciplines as diverse as engineering, business, psychology, English, history, music, and the arts. What matters most is not what you major in, but that you complete the required prerequisite coursework, perform well academically, and demonstrate the knowledge, experiences, and personal qualities expected of future dentists.

We encourage students to choose a major that genuinely interests them and aligns with their strengths, career goals, and intellectual curiosity. Students who enjoy their coursework are often more engaged in learning and better positioned to achieve strong academic performance. Your undergraduate education should provide opportunities to explore subjects beyond the sciences, develop critical thinking and communication skills, and cultivate a broad understanding of the world and the diverse populations you will serve as a healthcare professional.

Regardless of your major, it is important to plan your coursework carefully. Non-science majors will need to incorporate the required science prerequisites into their academic schedules, while science majors should take advantage of opportunities to broaden their education through coursework in the humanities, social sciences, business, ethics, psychology, communication, or the arts. A well-rounded education helps prepare future dentists to think critically, communicate effectively, and provide compassionate, patient-centered care.

Although completing the prerequisite courses is essential, admissions committees evaluate applicants holistically. Your academic record is considered alongside clinical experiences, shadowing, community service, leadership, research, employment, professionalism, and evidence that you have thoughtfully explored the profession. Choosing a major simply because you believe it will improve your chances of admission is rarely the best strategy. Instead, focus on pursuing a field of study that challenges you, supports your personal and professional growth, and allows you to perform at your highest level.

Your Faculty Advisor can help you plan your major, degree requirements, course selection, and sequencing. HPA can help you understand how dental school prerequisites and admissions considerations fit within that broader academic plan.

Dental School Prerequisites

Dental schools require applicants to complete a series of prerequisite science and general education courses before matriculation. While the courses listed below satisfy the requirements for the majority of U.S. dental schools, individual institutions establish their own prerequisite policies. Requirements may vary with respect to specific coursework, AP credit, online coursework, laboratory requirements, and the age of prerequisite courses.

Students should use this handbook as a starting point and carefully review the admissions requirements for every dental school to which they intend to apply. HPA can help you interpret dental school prerequisites and school-specific admissions requirements, while your Faculty Advisor remains your primary resource for course selection, sequencing, and degree requirements.

Subject	Common Villanova Course(s)	Note
Biology	- BIO 2105 & BIO 2106	2 Semesters w/ Labs Some schools may require or strongly prefer additional biology coursework. While AP Biology credit may satisfy introductory biology requirements at some dental schools, students should plan to complete at least two college-level biology courses with laboratories to meet the expectations of the broadest range of dental schools.
General Chemistry	- CHM 1151 & CHM 1103 AND - CHM 1152 & CHM 1104	2 Semesters w/ Labs
Organic Chemistry	- CHM 2211 & CHM 2201 AND - CHM 2212 & CHM 2202	2 Semesters w/ Labs
Physics	- PHY 1100 & PHY 1101 AND - PHY 1102 & PHY 1103 OR - PHY 2410 & PHY 2411 AND - PHY 2412 & PHY 2413	2 Semesters w/ Labs At least one semester of college-level calculus is required to take introductory physics at Villanova.
English / Writing	- ACS 1000	2 Semesters

	- ACS 1001 - ENG 1975	Most dental schools require one year of English or writing-intensive coursework. ACS 1000/1001 may satisfy these requirements at some institutions, and CLAS students also complete ENG 1975 as part of their degree requirements. Students outside CLAS may need additional English or writing-intensive coursework to meet the expectations of a broader range of dental schools. Work with your Faculty Advisor to identify appropriate coursework within your academic program and consult HPA regarding dental school requirements. Students should verify individual school policies.
Mathematics	- MAT 1312 - MAT 1500 OR EQUIVALENT	1-2 Semesters Most dental schools require at least one semester of mathematics.
Statistics	- STAT 1230 - STAT 1250 - STAT 1313 - CSC 2300 - PSY 2000	1 Semester May be a STAT course or a course within an alternate discipline such as psychology (PSY 2000). Course selection should be coordinated with the student's Faculty Advisor, as not all statistics courses satisfy requirements for every Villanova major. STAT 1230 and STAT 1250, for example, typically do not fulfill statistics requirements for CLAS STEM programs. PSY 2000 may also have limited availability for students outside the Psychology major.
Biochemistry	- CHM 4611 OR - CHM 4621	1 Semester CHM 4611 (Survey Biochemistry) covers a broad range of biochemical concepts. CHM 4621 (Biochemistry I) explores fewer topics in greater depth. Both courses require

		Organic Chemistry I & II as prerequisites. Work with your Faculty Advisor when selecting a course and consult HPA regarding dental school prerequisite and admissions considerations.
Human Anatomy & Physiology	- BIO 1205 & BIO 1206 OR - BIO 3055 & BIO 3085	Frequently Required or Strongly Recommended An increasing number of dental schools require or strongly recommend human anatomy and/or physiology. Students should consult their Faculty Advisor when selecting a sequence, as these courses may fulfill major or elective requirements differently, and course availability may vary.
Microbiology	- BIO 3595	Frequently Required or Recommended Many dental schools require or recommend microbiology. Students should verify individual school requirements.

School-Specific Requirements

While many dental schools require similar coursework, some require or strongly recommend additional classes such as Genetics, Psychology, or upper-level biomedical sciences.

Requirements can also change over time. It is your responsibility to verify the prerequisites for each school before submitting your application.

Advanced Placement (AP) Credit

Many dental schools accept Advanced Placement (AP) credit to satisfy prerequisite coursework, while others require applicants to complete additional college-level coursework in the same discipline. If you enter Villanova with AP credit, work with your Faculty Advisor to understand how that credit applies to your Villanova degree requirements and course placement. HPA can help you understand how individual dental schools may treat AP credit when evaluating prerequisite requirements.

Planning Your Coursework

Completing the prerequisite courses is only one aspect of preparing for dental school. Admissions committees also consider the rigor of your coursework, trends in academic performance, and success in upper-level science courses. Work with your Faculty Advisor to develop an appropriate course sequence within your degree program, and consult HPA about

how your prerequisite timing may affect DAT preparation and your intended dental school application timeline.

HPA Tip: Keep a running list of the dental schools you are considering and review their prerequisite requirements regularly. Small differences between schools, such as anatomy requirements, English coursework, or AP credit policies, can influence your academic planning.

GPA and Academic Performance

Why GPA Matters

Your undergraduate GPA is one of the most important indicators of your academic readiness for dental school. Dental education is rigorous and fast-paced, requiring students to master a large volume of scientific and clinical material while developing the technical skills needed to provide safe, effective patient care. Admissions committees use your academic record to evaluate not only what you have learned, but also whether you have demonstrated the consistency, discipline, and study habits necessary to succeed in a demanding professional curriculum.

What Admissions Committees Consider

Your GPA tells only part of the story. Dental schools evaluate multiple aspects of your academic record to determine whether you are prepared for the rigors of dental school. Rather than focusing on a single semester or course, admissions committees consider your performance over time, the strength of your science foundation, and the overall context of your undergraduate education.

Academic Factor	Why It Matters
Overall GPA	Demonstrates consistent academic achievement across all coursework.
Science GPA	Reflects readiness for the biomedical sciences taught in dental school.
Prerequisite Coursework	Shows mastery of the foundational sciences required for dental education.
Upper-Level Science Courses	Provides additional evidence of academic preparedness.
Academic Trends	Demonstrates growth, resilience, and continued development over time.

Building a Strong Academic Record

Strong academic preparation develops over time. Dental schools look for evidence that you can succeed in rigorous coursework while managing the other responsibilities and experiences that are part of your undergraduate education.

Plan your schedule carefully each semester, striving for an appropriate balance between challenging coursework and the time needed to succeed academically. Avoid overloading yourself with multiple demanding science courses if doing so may negatively impact your performance. Consistently strong grades earned over time are generally more beneficial than taking an unnecessarily heavy course load that compromises your academic success.

Develop effective study habits early in your undergraduate career and take advantage of available academic resources, including faculty office hours, tutoring, supplemental instruction, and study groups. If you begin to struggle in a course, seek assistance as soon as possible rather than waiting until the end of the semester. Addressing academic challenges early not only improves your chances of success but also demonstrates initiative and resilience.

Finally, remember that your academic record is only one component of a competitive application. Your goal should not be to earn perfect grades at the expense of your personal well-being or opportunities for growth. Instead, strive to maintain strong academic performance while engaging in meaningful clinical experiences, service, leadership, and extracurricular activities that contribute to your development as a future healthcare professional.

If Your GPA Isn't Where You Want It To Be

Many students experience academic challenges during college, whether due to adjusting to the demands of university coursework, personal circumstances, or simply discovering more effective study strategies over time. A semester or even a year of lower-than-expected grades does not automatically prevent you from becoming a competitive dental school applicant.

Admissions committees evaluate your academic record in context. An upward trend in academic performance, particularly in prerequisite and upper-level science courses, can demonstrate resilience, maturity, and your ability to succeed in a rigorous academic environment. Strong performance later in college may provide evidence that you have developed the knowledge, study habits, and time management skills necessary for success in dental school.

If you are concerned about your academic record, meet with HPA early to discuss how your academic performance may affect your dental school preparation and application timeline. Your Faculty Advisor can help you make decisions about course selection, sequencing, and degree progress, while HPA can help you determine whether additional academic preparation may strengthen your future application.

Remember that there is no single GPA that guarantees admission—or automatically disqualifies an applicant. The strongest applications reflect consistent effort, thoughtful planning, personal growth, and a sustained commitment to academic excellence. While grades are an important part of your application, they represent only one aspect of the holistic review process used by many dental schools.

HPA Tip: If you're struggling academically, don't wait until you're ready to apply to seek advice. Meeting with HPA early allows more time to evaluate your academic readiness, application timeline, and options for strengthening your preparation before you apply.

Planning Your Timeline

Preparing for dental school is a multi-year process. Starting early gives you time to complete prerequisites, explore the profession, prepare for the DAT, and develop your experiences without concentrating everything immediately before you apply.

While every student's path is unique, the timeline below reflects a traditional four-year undergraduate plan for students who intend to apply during the summer after their junior year and matriculate into dental school immediately following graduation. **Students planning to take one or more gap years may shift this timeline accordingly.**

First Year

- Begin prerequisite coursework in biology and chemistry.
 - Work with your Faculty Advisor on course selection and sequencing, and meet with HPA to discuss dental school prerequisites, career exploration, DAT planning, and your anticipated application timeline.
- Explore dentistry through shadowing, conversations with practicing dentists, and involvement in pre-dental organizations.
- Begin developing study habits that support long-term academic success.

Second Year

- Continue completing prerequisite coursework.
- Expand shadowing, community service, leadership, and other extracurricular experiences.
- Begin thinking about potential letter of recommendation writers.
- Meet with HPA to review your academic progress and long-term application plan.

Third Year

- Complete the majority of prerequisite coursework.
- Prepare for and take the Dental Admission Test (DAT), ideally after completing your foundational science courses.
- Continue building meaningful clinical, service, and leadership experiences.
- Request letters of recommendation.
- Prepare your ADEA AADSAS application and plan to submit it early in the application cycle.

Fourth Year

- Complete any remaining degree or prerequisite requirements.
- Participate in interviews and complete supplemental applications as requested.
- Maintain strong academic performance throughout your senior year.
- Continue building meaningful clinical, service, and leadership experiences.
- Prepare for the transition to dental school.

Considering a Gap Year?

Many successful applicants choose to take one or more gap years before dental school. If you plan to do so, your application timeline will shift accordingly, but the sequence of preparation – academic readiness, meaningful experiences, DAT preparation, and application submission – remains the same.

Building a Competitive Application

Shadowing

Shadowing is one of the most valuable, and often expected, components of a competitive dental school application. Beyond demonstrating your commitment to the profession, shadowing provides firsthand exposure to the day-to-day responsibilities of a dentist and helps you determine whether dentistry is the right career for you. It also allows you to observe the clinical, interpersonal, and ethical aspects of patient care that cannot be fully appreciated from the perspective of a patient.

Most dental schools expect applicants to have meaningful shadowing experience, although the number of hours required or recommended varies by institution. Many schools prefer that the majority of your shadowing be completed with a general dentist, as this provides the broadest understanding of comprehensive dental practice. Once you have gained experience in general dentistry, consider observing one or more dental specialties to better understand the diversity of career paths within the profession. Because expectations vary among schools, review the admissions requirements for each program to which you intend to apply.

As you shadow, focus on more than the clinical procedures being performed. Observe how the dentist communicates with patients, works alongside hygienists and dental assistants, manages unexpected challenges, discusses treatment options, and balances patient care with the operational responsibilities of a dental practice. These observations will help you develop a realistic understanding of the profession while preparing you to discuss your experiences in application essays and interviews.

Shadowing experiences are most valuable when they occur over time and across a variety of patient encounters rather than being completed in a single block immediately before applying. Longitudinal experiences demonstrate sustained interest in the profession and provide greater opportunities to reflect on what you have learned.

Making the Most of Your Shadowing Experiences

As you shadow, pay attention to how dentists communicate with patients, work with the dental team, respond to challenges, and approach clinical decision-making. Reflect on what you learn about the profession and how those observations influence your own interest in dentistry.

HPA Tip: Keep a record of your shadowing experiences, including dates, hours, practice settings, and brief reflections about what you observed and learned. These notes can be invaluable when completing your ADEA AADSAS application and preparing for interviews.

Clinical Experience

While shadowing allows you to observe the profession, clinical experience provides opportunities to actively engage in patient care or work within a healthcare environment. Clinical experiences help you develop professionalism, communication skills, teamwork, and a deeper understanding of patient-centered care while demonstrating your commitment to serving others.

Unlike medical school admissions, many dental schools place greater emphasis on meaningful shadowing than extensive clinical employment. However, hands-on clinical experiences can strengthen your application by providing additional insight into healthcare delivery, patient interactions, and the responsibilities of oral healthcare professionals. Clinical experience may also be gained through paid employment.

Clinical experiences may be completed in dental or non-dental settings. Working directly with dental patients can provide valuable exposure to clinical procedures and office operations, while broader healthcare experiences can help develop communication skills, empathy, and an appreciation for caring for diverse patient populations. Clinical experience can complement, but does not replace, meaningful exposure to dentistry. Applicants should have sufficient dental shadowing and/or dental experience to demonstrate that their decision to pursue dentistry is informed by firsthand exposure to the profession.

Examples of impactful clinical experiences include:

- Dental assistant (paid or volunteer)
- Sterilization technician in a dental practice
- Volunteer in a community dental clinic or federally qualified health center
- Dental outreach programs and mobile dental clinics
- Hospital volunteer with direct patient interaction
- Emergency department volunteer
- Certified Nursing Assistant (CNA)
- Emergency Medical Technician (EMT)
- Medical assistant
- Hospice volunteer
- Patient transporter
- Patient care technician (PCT)
- Phlebotomist
- Registered behavior technician (RBT) or other patient-facing healthcare roles

Prioritize clinical experiences that involve meaningful patient interaction and give you opportunities to develop communication, professionalism, and patient-care skills. Consider what you learn from these roles and how they shape your understanding of healthcare.

HPA Tip: While direct dental experience is valuable, meaningful clinical experiences outside of dentistry can also strengthen your application by demonstrating compassion, communication skills, and a commitment to caring for others. **Your overall record should demonstrate sustained and informed engagement with the dental profession.**

Community Service

Service is a core value of the healthcare professions, and dentistry is no exception. Dentists have a unique opportunity to improve not only their patients' oral health, but also their confidence, quality of life, and overall well-being. Demonstrating a sustained commitment to serving others helps admissions committees understand your motivation for pursuing a career centered on improving the lives of individuals and communities.

Choose service opportunities that you genuinely care about and can engage with consistently over time. Admissions committees value applicants who have consistently dedicated their time to causes they care about, particularly those that involve working with individuals whose backgrounds or life experiences differ from their own. These experiences foster empathy, cultural humility, communication skills, and a broader understanding of the social and environmental factors that influence health.

Meaningful service can take many forms and does not need to be healthcare-related. In fact, many impactful service experiences occur outside of clinical settings and allow students to develop relationships with the communities they serve.

Examples of substantive community service include:

- Food banks and community meal programs
- Homeless shelters
- Habitat for Humanity
- Youth mentoring or tutoring programs
- Big Brothers Big Sisters
- Special Olympics
- Crisis text lines or peer support programs
- Volunteer work with older adults
- Programs serving individuals with disabilities
- Animal shelters and humane societies
- Faith-based or community organizations
- Oral health education and community outreach events
- Free dental clinics or dental mission programs

Long-term involvement in one or two organizations often provides more opportunity to build relationships, contribute consistently, and reflect on what you have learned.

Reflect on what you learn from the people and communities you serve, including how the experience challenges your assumptions or changes your understanding of others. This reflection can also help you discuss your service experiences more clearly in applications and interviews.

Leadership

Dentists are leaders in many different capacities. Whether coordinating a dental team, educating patients, managing a practice, mentoring colleagues, or advocating for improved access to care, dentists must be able to communicate effectively, collaborate with others, and make thoughtful decisions in complex situations. As a result, admissions committees value applicants who have demonstrated leadership and the ability to positively influence those around them.

Leadership can take many forms, including taking initiative, solving problems, supporting peers, or helping a group accomplish a shared goal. Admissions committees are often more interested in how you led than what your title was.

Leadership experiences may be found in a variety of settings, including:

- Student organizations and clubs
- Pre-dental or pre-health organizations
- Resident assistant (RA) or orientation leader positions
- Peer mentoring or tutoring
- Teaching assistant (TA) roles
- Athletics or club sports
- Student government
- Research teams
- Community service organizations
- Religious or cultural organizations
- Employment or supervisory roles

Consider how your experiences have challenged you to communicate effectively, resolve conflict, motivate others, manage responsibilities, and adapt to unexpected situations. These are the same skills you will rely upon throughout your career as a dentist.

Research

Research is not required for admission to most dental schools, but it can be a valuable part of an applicant's undergraduate experience. Research develops skills in scientific inquiry, critical thinking, problem-solving, data analysis, and collaboration, all of which are relevant to dental education and evidence-based practice.

Research opportunities may be found in the biological sciences, chemistry, engineering, psychology, public health, or other disciplines. Students interested in research should pursue areas that align with their academic interests rather than selecting a project solely because they believe dental schools expect research experience.

Research experiences may occur in:

- Basic science laboratories
- Clinical research
- Public health
- Engineering
- Psychology
- Social sciences
- Humanities
- Education

💡 Students interested in research are encouraged to explore opportunities through [Villanova's Center for Research & Fellowships \(CRF\)](#), which supports undergraduate research, faculty mentorship, funding opportunities, summer research, and nationally competitive fellowships.

The importance of research may vary depending on the dental schools you are considering and your individual goals. Applicants interested in research-intensive dental schools, academic dentistry, or combined research and clinical careers may benefit from more substantial involvement.

Manual Dexterity

Manual dexterity is a unique and important aspect of preparing for a career in dentistry. According to the [American Dental Education Association \(ADEA\)](#), manual dexterity is the ability to use your hands in a skillful, coordinated manner to grasp and manipulate objects while performing small, precise movements. Because dentists routinely perform procedures within a very small operating field, exceptional hand-eye coordination, fine motor control, and precision are essential for providing safe and effective patient care.

For this reason, many dental schools consider evidence of manual dexterity during the admissions process. The Dental Admission Test (DAT) includes the Perceptual Ability Test (PAT), which assesses spatial reasoning and visualization skills that are important for dental practice. In addition, admissions committees frequently ask applicants to discuss how they have developed their manual dexterity through hobbies, employment, artistic pursuits, or other experiences.

Fortunately, manual dexterity is a skill that can be developed through practice. Admissions committees do not expect applicants to pursue a particular manual-dexterity activity. They are

more interested in evidence that you have developed coordination, precision, and comfort working with your hands.

Examples of activities that demonstrate or strengthen manual dexterity include:

- Drawing or sketching
- Painting
- Sculpture or ceramics
- Jewelry making
- Woodworking or woodcarving
- Sewing, embroidery, or needlepoint
- Knitting or crocheting
- Soap carving
- Model building
- Learning and playing a musical instrument (e.g., piano, violin, guitar)
- Fly tying or tying fishing knots
- Dental laboratory or assisting experiences requiring fine motor skills

The goal is not to accumulate a long list of hobbies, but to genuinely engage in activities that require patience, coordination, and precision. If you find that you enjoy these types of activities, they may reinforce your interest in dentistry while helping you develop skills that will be valuable throughout dental school and your professional career. Conversely, if you consistently find meticulous, hands-on work frustrating or unfulfilling, it is worth reflecting on whether dentistry is the right fit for your interests and strengths.

HPA Tip: Choose activities you genuinely enjoy and practice them consistently. Manual dexterity develops through repeated use and practice.

Professional Competencies

Strong grades and meaningful experiences are essential components of a competitive application, but they are only part of what admissions committees evaluate. Dental schools are also seeking applicants who demonstrate the personal and professional qualities necessary to become ethical, compassionate, and effective oral healthcare providers.

The American Dental Education Association (ADEA) identifies [Domains of Competence](#) for entry-level general dentists across integrated clinical practice, leadership, and community and population health. Although these competencies are developed during dental school, many of the underlying qualities, including critical thinking, professionalism, communication, collaboration, and service, begin developing well before admission.

Throughout your undergraduate education, look for opportunities to develop and demonstrate competencies such as:

Quality or Skill	Examples of How It May Be Demonstrated
Critical Thinking	Solving complex problems, conducting research, analyzing scientific literature, making thoughtful decisions
Professionalism	Reliability, integrity, accountability, ethical behavior, respecting commitments, appropriate conduct
Communication	Patient interactions, tutoring, leadership, customer service, public speaking, teamwork
Interpersonal Skills	Collaboration, empathy, conflict resolution, cultural humility, working with diverse populations
Service Orientation	Community service, outreach, advocacy, improving access to care
Adaptability & Resilience	Overcoming academic or personal challenges, responding constructively to feedback, balancing competing responsibilities
Leadership	Mentoring others, initiating projects, organizing teams, serving in leadership roles

These qualities develop across your academics, employment, service, research, leadership, and interactions with others. As you prepare to apply, consider both what you have done and what those experiences have taught you.

The Application Process

Application Components Overview

Each component of the dental school application provides different information about your academic preparation, experiences, personal qualities, and readiness for dental school. Admissions committees consider these materials together when reviewing applicants.

Application Component	Purpose
ADEA AADSAS Application	The centralized application through which applicants submit academic information, experiences, personal information, and supporting materials to participating U.S. dental schools.
Official Transcripts	Verify your academic record, prerequisite coursework, and cumulative and science GPAs.
Dental Admission Test (DAT)	A standardized exam that assesses academic preparedness, scientific knowledge, perceptual ability, reading comprehension, and quantitative reasoning.
Personal Statement	An opportunity to explain your motivation for pursuing dentistry and reflect on the experiences that have prepared you for the profession.
Experiences Section	Documents your involvement in shadowing, clinical experiences, community service, leadership, research, employment, manual dexterity activities, and other meaningful experiences.
Letters of Recommendation	Provide admissions committees with independent evaluations of your academic ability, professionalism, character, and readiness for dental school.
Supplemental (Secondary) Applications	Many dental schools require additional essays, questions, or fees after receiving your AADSAS application.
Interviews	Allow admissions committees to assess your communication skills, professionalism, interpersonal abilities, and overall fit for their program.

The DAT

The Dental Admission Test (DAT) is a standardized examination developed by the American Dental Association (ADA) and is required by nearly all U.S. dental schools as part of the admissions process. The exam is designed to assess the academic knowledge, scientific reasoning, perceptual ability, and critical thinking skills that are important for success in dental school.

Unlike your undergraduate GPA, which reflects your performance over several years, the DAT provides admissions committees with a standardized measure of your academic preparation.

The DAT is administered year-round at Prometric testing centers throughout the United States and Canada. Because official scores are transmitted directly to the ADEA AADSAS application, students should plan their testing timeline carefully to ensure scores are available early in the application cycle.

DAT performance is important, but it is considered alongside the rest of your application. A strong score does not guarantee admission, and a lower score does not necessarily prevent an otherwise competitive applicant from receiving consideration.

DAT Sections

Section	What It Assesses
Survey of the Natural Sciences	Foundational knowledge in biology, general chemistry, and organic chemistry.
Perceptual Ability Test (PAT)	Spatial reasoning, visualization, and perceptual skills important for dentistry.
Reading Comprehension	Ability to read, analyze, and interpret scientific information.
Quantitative Reasoning	Mathematical reasoning, algebra, data analysis, and problem-solving.

DAT Timeline

The ideal time to take the Dental Admission Test (DAT) depends on your individual academic preparation and application timeline rather than your undergraduate class year. In general, you should plan to take the DAT after completing the foundational science coursework covered on the exam and before submitting your ADEA AADSAS application. This allows your official scores to be available early in the application cycle while ensuring you have sufficient time to prepare.

Although the DAT is offered year-round, dental school admissions operate on a rolling basis. Applications submitted earlier in the cycle are often reviewed sooner, making it advantageous to

have your DAT completed before or shortly after submitting your application. Waiting until late in the application cycle to test may delay review of your application at some schools.

Do not take the DAT before you have completed the appropriate coursework and had sufficient time to prepare. A premature test date may result in a score that does not accurately reflect your preparation.

If you are an alumnus, career changer, or planning one or more gap years, work backward from the application cycle in which you intend to apply. Your goal should be to complete the DAT with enough time to receive your scores, evaluate your application, and, if necessary, make informed decisions about retesting before applying.

HPA Tip: Before registering for the DAT, meet with your Health Professions Advisor to discuss your coursework, study plan, and intended application timeline. Taking the exam at the right time can strengthen your application and reduce unnecessary stress throughout the admissions process.

Preparing for the DAT

DAT preparation requires consistent study and a realistic assessment of your strengths and areas for improvement. Most students dedicate approximately 2–4 months of focused preparation, although the amount of time needed varies depending on your academic background, familiarity with the material, and other personal or academic commitments.

Begin by evaluating your foundation in the natural sciences and identifying content areas that require additional review. Develop a structured study schedule that allows time for content review, practice questions, full-length practice exams, and regular review of your mistakes. While mastering scientific concepts is essential, remember that the DAT also evaluates time management, reading comprehension, quantitative reasoning, and perceptual ability – skills that improve through consistent practice.

As your exam date approaches, shift your focus from learning new content to applying what you know under testing conditions. Full-length practice exams help build endurance, improve pacing, and identify areas that need additional review before test day. Just as importantly, spend time analyzing your practice exams to understand why you missed questions rather than simply noting your score.

The American Dental Association (ADA), which administers the DAT, recommends that applicants use the [official Candidate Guide](#), practice tests, and reference materials to become familiar with the exam format and expectations. While many students also choose to use commercial preparation programs, the ADA does not endorse any specific test preparation company. The resources below include official ADA materials and commonly used commercial

preparation programs. Consider cost, structure, and your individual learning needs when choosing study resources.

Resource	Description
ADA DAT Candidate Guide	Official guide containing exam policies, scoring information, test specifications, and testing procedures.
ADA DAT Practice Tests & Tutorial	Official practice materials written by the developers of the DAT to familiarize students with the format and style of the examination.
DAT Bootcamp	A comprehensive commercial preparation program that includes content review, practice questions, full-length exams, study schedules, and analytics.
DAT Booster	A comprehensive commercial preparation program featuring content review, extensive question banks, practice exams, and study schedules. Widely used by pre-dental applicants.

DAT Scores and Retaking

The DAT includes several individual section scores as well as composite scores that summarize your overall performance. Since March 2025, DAT scores have been reported on a 200–600 scale in 10-point increments. Because admissions practices vary among dental schools, there is no universal score that guarantees admission or automatically disqualifies an applicant. Some schools place greater emphasis on overall performance, while others may pay closer attention to specific section scores that align with their admissions priorities. Applicants are encouraged to review the admissions information published by the schools to which they intend to apply.

If your DAT score does not accurately reflect your academic ability or preparation, you may choose to retake the exam. Before scheduling another attempt, carefully evaluate whether additional preparation is likely to produce a meaningful improvement. Simply repeating the same study strategy may not lead to a different outcome. Instead, identify the factors that contributed to your performance, adjust your study plan accordingly, and allow sufficient time to strengthen areas of weakness before testing again.

Keep in mind that the American Dental Association (ADA) places limits on the number and timing of DAT attempts. Be sure to review the current DAT Candidate Guide for the most up-to-date retesting policies before registering for another exam.

HPA Tip: Before deciding to retake the DAT, meet with your Health Professions Advisor to review your academic record, DAT performance, and school list. In some cases, strengthening other aspects of your application may be a better strategy than immediately retesting.

The ADEA Associated American Dental Schools Application Service (AADSAS)

The ADEA Associated American Dental Schools Application Service (AADSAS) is the centralized application service used by the majority of U.S. dental schools. Applicants submit one centralized application through AADSAS, which is distributed to the participating dental schools they designate. Individual schools may subsequently require supplemental applications, additional essays, or application fees.

The AADSAS application allows applicants to present a comprehensive picture of their academic preparation, experiences, and motivation for pursuing dentistry. In addition to demographic and academic information, applicants report coursework, extracurricular activities, employment, research, community service, shadowing, manual dexterity experiences, achievements, and letters of recommendation. The application also includes a personal statement, providing applicants with an opportunity to explain their journey toward a career in dentistry.

Because AADSAS is the primary application used by most dental schools, it is important to begin preparing well before the application opens. Gathering transcripts, requesting letters of recommendation, documenting experiences, and drafting application essays in advance can make the submission process significantly less stressful and help ensure your application is complete early in the admissions cycle.

Applying Early Matters

Most U.S. dental schools utilize rolling admissions, meaning applications are reviewed as they become complete rather than waiting until after the application deadline. As interview invitations and acceptance offers are extended throughout the admissions cycle, the number of available seats gradually decreases. For this reason, applicants are generally encouraged to submit a complete, accurate application as early in the application cycle as possible.

Submitting early, however, should never come at the expense of quality. Your goal should be to submit the strongest application you can while still taking advantage of the benefits of early review. This includes allowing adequate time to prepare for the DAT, thoughtfully completing your application, securing strong letters of recommendation, and carefully reviewing all materials before submission.

HPA Tip: Start preparing your AADSAS application months before it opens. Draft your personal statement, update your résumé, organize your experiences, and request letters of recommendation well in advance. When the application becomes available, you'll be ready to focus on refining, not rushing, your submission.

Timeframe	Typical Activities
Spring	Finalize school list, request letters, prepare personal statement, register for or complete the DAT.
May	ADEA AADSAS application opens. Begin entering coursework and experiences.
Early Summer	Submit your completed AADSAS application as early as possible once all materials are ready.
Summer–Winter	Complete supplemental applications and participate in interviews.
Fall-Early Spring	Receive admissions decisions and prepare for matriculation that fall.

Applying to Dental Schools in Texas

Applicants to participating Texas dental schools use the Texas Medical and Dental Schools Application Service (TMDSAS) rather than ADEA AADSAS. Students considering Texas dental schools should review the TMDSAS application requirements and timeline separately.

Selecting Dental Schools

Choosing where to apply is an important part of the dental school application process. Dental schools differ in their prerequisite requirements, admissions criteria, educational programs, clinical experiences, missions, geographic preferences, and cost.

As you develop your school list, consider factors such as:

- Prerequisite and course requirements
- GPA and DAT expectations
- Mission and educational priorities
- Clinical training opportunities
- Location and geographic preferences
- State residency preferences
- Class size and learning environment
- Tuition, fees, and cost of living
- Supplemental application requirements
- Opportunities in areas that interest you, such as research, public health, or community-based dentistry

Use school-specific admissions information to determine whether each program is a reasonable fit for your academic profile, experiences, and goals. The [ADEA Dental School Explorer](#) and individual dental school admissions websites are useful starting points.

Personal Statement

The personal statement is one of the few components of your dental school application that allows admissions committees to hear your voice. While your transcripts, DAT scores, and experiences describe what you have accomplished, the personal statement helps explain why you are pursuing dentistry and how your experiences have prepared you for the profession.

A strong personal statement explains your motivation for pursuing dentistry through reflection on the experiences that shaped your decision and the qualities you will bring to the profession.

As you begin writing, focus on reflection rather than description. Consider the experiences that have most influenced your development, challenged your perspectives, or reinforced your commitment to dentistry. Focus on providing genuine insight into your character, values, and professional aspirations rather than trying to make your story sound unusually dramatic.

A strong personal statement should:

- Clearly explain your motivation for pursuing dentistry.
- Reflect on the experiences that shaped your interest in dentistry.
- Highlight qualities such as compassion, professionalism, resilience, and integrity.
- Show how your experiences have prepared you for the profession.
- Be authentic, well organized, and free of grammatical or spelling errors.

Remember that your personal statement is often the first opportunity for admissions committees to get to know you beyond your academic metrics. Take the time to revise your essay through multiple drafts, seek constructive feedback, and allow your own voice to remain at the center of the narrative.

Personal Statement Support at Villanova

The Health Professions Advising Program strongly encourages students to take advantage of the writing support available through Villanova's Career Center. John McGranaghan, Assistant Director of the Career Center, has extensive experience helping pre-health students develop compelling personal statements and application essays.

Students are encouraged to meet with both HPA and John McGranaghan in the Career Center throughout the writing process. HPA can provide guidance on the content of your essay and how it reflects your preparation for dentistry, while the Career Center can help strengthen your writing, organization, clarity, and overall presentation. Beginning early allows ample time for thoughtful revisions and multiple rounds of feedback before submitting your application.

Letters of Recommendation

Letters of recommendation (LORs) provide dental schools with an independent assessment of your academic ability, professionalism, character, and readiness for a career in dentistry. Strong letters offer insight into who you are beyond your GPA, DAT score, and list of experiences.

The best letters come from individuals who know you well and can speak to your strengths through specific examples, not simply those with impressive titles.

Who Should Write My Letters?

Letter requirements vary by dental school. Many schools request letters from science faculty members, and some also require or recommend a letter from a practicing dentist. Always review the specific requirements for every program to which you plan to apply. Because requirements vary among schools, always review the specific admissions requirements for every program to which you plan to apply.

Potential letter writers may include:

- Science faculty members who taught you in biology, chemistry, physics, or other laboratory science courses
- A practicing dentist who has observed your shadowing, employment, or volunteer experiences
- Research mentors or principal investigators
- Employment supervisors
- Faculty Advisors or mentors
- Volunteer or community service supervisors

HPA has a letter packet process outlined below.

What Makes a Strong Letter?

Strong recommendation letters are written by individuals who know you well and can comment on your:

- Academic ability
- Critical thinking and intellectual curiosity
- Communication skills
- Professionalism
- Reliability and work ethic
- Leadership
- Teamwork
- Compassion and interpersonal skills
- Readiness for dental school

Building Relationships with Potential Recommenders

Students should begin developing relationships with faculty and mentors well before applying to dental school.

Consider:

- Attending office hours
- Participating actively in class
- Seeking research opportunities
- Serving as a teaching assistant or peer tutor
- Staying in contact after completing a course
- Asking thoughtful questions and seeking mentorship

Strong letters are built over time.

When Should I Ask?

Plan to request letters at least 2–3 months before you need them, and ideally before the end of the semester if asking a faculty member.

Giving recommenders plenty of time allows them to write thoughtful, detailed letters.

What Should I Provide to My Recommenders?

To help your recommender write a strong letter, consider providing:

- Current resume or CV
- Unofficial transcript
- Personal statement draft (if available)
- Brief statement describing why you are pursuing dentistry
- List of schools (optional)
- Summary of experiences since taking their course or working with them
- Submission instructions and deadlines

Providing this information allows recommenders to write more personalized and detailed letters.

Waiving Your Right to View Letters

Applicants are generally encouraged to waive their right to view recommendation letters.

Dental schools often place greater confidence in confidential letters because they are more likely to represent an honest assessment.

Villanova Health Professions Advising Letter Packet Process

Many schools require, or strongly prefer, a letter packet compiled by Health Professions Advising (HPA) when possible. HPA has a process in place to support students applying to dental school, including the collection and submission of letters of recommendation. Students are not required to submit a letter packet through HPA for their applications, but it is strongly recommended.

HPA Letter Packet Interest Form and Application

Step 1: Submit the HPA Letter Packet Interest Form

- The HPA Letter Packet Interest Form will be available in mid-October for students considering applying in the upcoming cycle. The form will be available through [HPA Brightspace](#) and [HPA Career Connections](#).
- For students applying in the **2027–2028 cycle**, the Interest Form is due Friday, **January 15, 2027**.
- **Students who do not submit the Interest Form by the January 15 deadline will not be eligible to participate in the HPA letter packet process for the 2027–2028 cycle.**

Step 2: Complete the HPA Letter Packet Slate Application

- The HPA Letter Packet Slate Application for the **2027–2028 cycle** will open in Slate on **Tuesday, January 19, 2027**. The application link will be emailed to students who submitted the Interest Form by the deadline.
- Instructions and required forms will be provided within the Slate application.

Step 3: Upload Application Preparation Materials

- Students must upload the following materials to Slate by **Friday, April 2, 2027**:
 - Unofficial transcripts from *all* attended institutions, including Villanova University, community colleges, etc.
 - Polished draft of personal statement
 - Resume/CV
 - Pre-Meeting Questionnaire
- After uploading these materials, students are required to meet with an HPA advisor for an application preparation meeting. **Completion of this meeting is required to receive an HPA letter packet.**

Step 4: Complete Letter Packet Requirements

- HPA will collect individual letters of recommendation and evaluations directly from recommenders. Applicants must provide a **minimum of three and maximum of five letters of recommendation.**
- Before HPA can submit a letter packet, the following must also be completed in Slate:
 - Code Form
 - Authorization of Release
 - Names and contact information of recommenders
 - All required letters of recommendation and evaluations received by HPA
- Required HPA application preparation meeting completed

Step 5: Packet Compilation and Submission

- Letter packet compilation begins in May. HPA will submit the completed packet to the appropriate centralized application service once all requirements have been completed.
- **The Slate application and all remaining letter packet requirements must be completed no later than September 1, 2027.** HPA will not process letter packets for students who have not completed all requirements by this deadline.

2027 HPA Letter Packet Process Important Dates & Deadlines	
Mid-October 2026	HPA Letter Packet Interest Form Available on Brightspace and Career Connections
January 15, 2027	HPA Letter Packet Interest Form Due
January 19, 2027	HPA Letter Packet Slate Application Available
April 2, 2027	Application preparation materials listed in Step 3 due in Slate
March-May 2027	Meet with HPA advisor for application prep meeting
September 1, 2027	Final Letter Packet Completion Deadline

Interviews

Receiving an interview invitation means that a dental school is interested in learning more about you beyond the information included in your application. Interviews allow schools to evaluate qualities such as communication, professionalism, interpersonal skills, ethical reasoning, self-awareness, and motivation for pursuing dentistry.

Dental schools may use traditional one-on-one or panel interviews, Multiple Mini Interviews (MMIs), group activities, or a combination of formats. Interviews may be conducted virtually or in person.

Before an interview:

- Review your application and be prepared to discuss your experiences.
- Reflect on why you want to become a dentist.
- Research the school's mission, curriculum, and clinical opportunities.
- Practice discussing your experiences clearly and naturally.
- Prepare thoughtful questions about the program.
- Review the interview format provided by the school.

Applicants should prepare thoroughly without memorizing scripted answers. Be ready to discuss your shadowing experiences, understanding of dentistry, strengths and areas for growth, ethical or interpersonal situations, and reasons for applying to the particular school.

Gap Years & Academic Enhancement

Gap Years

Many applicants take one or more gap years before dental school to gain experience, strengthen areas of their application, or apply when they are better prepared. Dental schools are accustomed to applicants following different timelines.

Students choose to take gap years for many reasons. Some wish to gain additional clinical or shadowing experience, while others pursue research, community service, employment, or leadership opportunities that strengthen their understanding of the profession and enhance their readiness for dental school. Some students use this time to prepare for or retake the DAT, while others simply appreciate the opportunity to transition into professional school with greater confidence and maturity.

Use your gap year in ways that support your individual goals and continued preparation for dental school. Admissions committees are interested in applicants who demonstrate continued growth, sustained commitment, and thoughtful use of their time between graduation and matriculation.

Making the Most of a Gap Year

Choose gap-year activities based on your individual goals and the areas of your preparation you want to strengthen.

Examples include:

- Working as a dental assistant or in another patient-facing healthcare role
- Expanding shadowing experiences in general dentistry and dental specialties
- Participating in community service or public health initiatives
- Conducting research
- Completing additional coursework or academic enhancement (if appropriate)
- Preparing for or retaking the DAT (if appropriate)
- Gaining leadership experience through employment or volunteer organizations
- Saving money to help offset the cost of the application process or dental school

Whether your goal is to strengthen your application or gain additional life experience, a well-planned gap year can help you enter dental school with greater confidence, stronger professional skills, and a deeper understanding of the profession.

Academic Enhancement

For some students, additional academic preparation after graduation may be beneficial before applying to dental school. Academic enhancement can strengthen an application by

demonstrating improved academic performance, reinforcing foundational science knowledge, or completing prerequisite coursework. It is not necessary—or appropriate—for every applicant. Whether academic enhancement is recommended depends on your individual academic record, DAT performance, and the expectations of the dental schools to which you plan to apply.

Two common pathways for academic enhancement are post-baccalaureate (post-bacc) programs and Specialized Master's Programs (SMPs).

Program Type	Purpose
Post-Baccalaureate Program	Designed for students who need to complete prerequisite coursework, improve their undergraduate GPA, or demonstrate stronger academic performance through additional undergraduate-level science courses.
Specialized Master's Program (SMP)	Graduate-level programs that provide advanced biomedical science coursework similar to the first year of professional school. These programs are generally intended for applicants who have completed the prerequisites but need to demonstrate their ability to succeed in a rigorous graduate-level curriculum.

Academic enhancement is only one way to strengthen an application. Depending on your individual circumstances, improving your DAT score, gaining additional clinical or shadowing experiences, expanding your service involvement, or delaying your application to continue developing professionally may be more appropriate than pursuing additional coursework.

Post-baccalaureate programs and SMPs require a significant investment of time and money. Additional coursework is most useful when it addresses a specific academic need; enrolling in a program does not automatically make an applicant more competitive.

HPA Tip: Before pursuing a post-baccalaureate program, SMP, or other form of academic enhancement, meet with your Health Professions Advisor. Together, you can evaluate your academic record, discuss your career goals, and determine whether academic enhancement – or another strategy – is the most effective way to strengthen your application.

Frequently Asked Questions

Exploring Dentistry as a Career FAQ

Do I have to know I want to be a dentist before starting college?

No. Many successful dental school applicants discover an interest in dentistry during college after exploring healthcare careers through coursework, shadowing, volunteer experiences, or conversations with practicing dentists. The purpose of career exploration is to help you make an informed decision before committing to the application process.

How can I tell if dentistry is the right career for me?

The best way to determine whether dentistry is the right fit is to explore the profession firsthand. Shadowing dentists, speaking with dental professionals, participating in community service, and reflecting on your experiences will help you develop a realistic understanding of the profession and whether it aligns with your interests, strengths, and career goals.

Do I need to shadow multiple dental specialties?

Not necessarily. Most dental schools prefer that the majority of your shadowing be completed with a general dentist, as this provides the broadest understanding of comprehensive dental care. Observing one or more specialties can broaden your perspective, but meaningful exposure to general dentistry should be your priority.

Can I switch to pre-dental later in college?

Yes. Students enter the pre-dental pathway at many different points during their undergraduate education. If you decide to pursue dentistry later in college, meet with HPA to discuss dental school prerequisites and your application timeline, and work with your Faculty Advisor to determine how prerequisite coursework fits within your degree plan.

Academic Preparation FAQ

Can I major in something other than biology?

Yes. Dental schools accept applicants from a wide variety of academic majors, provided they complete the required prerequisite coursework. Choose a major that interests you, aligns with your strengths, and allows you to perform well academically.

Will AP credit satisfy dental school prerequisites?

It depends on the dental school. Some schools accept Advanced Placement (AP) credit, while others require additional college-level coursework in the same subject. Always review the admissions requirements for each school to which you plan to apply.

What if I earn a C in a prerequisite course?

A single C does not automatically prevent you from being admitted to dental school, but repeated low grades or poor performance in prerequisite science courses may make you less competitive. If you're concerned about your academic record, meet with HPA to discuss strategies for strengthening your application before applying.

Do dental schools look at my science GPA separately from my overall GPA?

Yes. Through ADEA AADSAS, dental schools receive both your cumulative GPA and your science GPA. Admissions committees consider both when evaluating your academic preparation, along with factors such as course rigor, prerequisite performance, and academic trends.

Should I take additional upper-level science courses beyond the prerequisites?

It depends. Some dental schools require or recommend additional sciences such as anatomy, physiology, microbiology, or other upper-level biology courses, while other applicants may benefit from advanced coursework for academic preparation or DAT readiness. Work with your Faculty Advisor to determine which courses fit your academic interests, degree requirements, and course sequence, and consult HPA about dental school requirements and admissions strategy.

Building a Competitive Application FAQ

How much shadowing do I need?

There is no universal shadowing requirement. Many dental schools recommend or require shadowing experience, often with a general dentist, but the number of hours varies by institution. Focus on gaining enough experience to understand the profession and discuss what you learned, not simply reaching a particular number of hours.

Do I need research to be competitive?

Research is not required for admission to most dental schools, but it can strengthen your application by demonstrating critical thinking, problem-solving, and intellectual curiosity. If you participate in research, focus on understanding the research process and your role in the work.

Can I count paid employment as experience?

Absolutely. Meaningful employment – whether in a dental office, healthcare setting, or another industry – can demonstrate responsibility, professionalism, communication skills, and time management. Admissions committees value sustained commitment and recognize that balancing employment with academics is a significant accomplishment.

How important is manual dexterity?

Manual dexterity is an important attribute for future dentists because the profession requires precise, coordinated hand movements and fine motor skills. Dental schools may evaluate manual dexterity through your experiences, interview discussions, and the Perceptual Ability Test (PAT) section of the DAT. Activities such as playing a musical instrument, sewing, woodworking, drawing, painting, or model building can help develop these skills.

Should all of my experiences be dentistry-related?

No. While meaningful shadowing and exposure to dentistry are essential, admissions committees also value experiences that demonstrate service, leadership, teamwork, communication, and personal growth. A well-rounded application reflects both your commitment to dentistry and your development as a compassionate, engaged, and resilient individual.

DAT and Application Process FAQ

When should I submit my ADEA AADSAS application?

Submit your application as early as possible once it is complete and you are confident it reflects your strongest work. Because most dental schools use rolling admissions, early submission allows your application to be reviewed while more interview invitations and seats remain available.

Can I submit my application before taking the DAT?

Yes, but this should be part of a larger application strategy. You may submit your ADEA AADSAS application before taking the DAT, but many schools will not consider your application complete until official DAT scores are received. If possible, plan to complete the DAT before or shortly after submitting your application to avoid unnecessary delays. Students are strongly encouraged to discuss this timeline and strategy with HPA beforehand.

Should I retake the DAT?

A DAT retake should be a strategic decision rather than an automatic response to a disappointing score. Consider your overall application, the schools to which you plan to apply, and whether additional preparation is likely to result in meaningful improvement. Discuss your situation with HPA before scheduling another attempt.

How many dental schools should I apply to?

There is no ideal number that fits every applicant. Your school list should include programs that align with your academic metrics, experiences, career goals, geographic preferences, and financial considerations. HPA can help you develop a balanced and realistic list based on your individual profile.

Can I update my application after I submit it?

Some information, such as new experiences, additional dental school designations, updated DAT scores, and certain contact information, can be added after submission. However, many sections, including your personal statement and previously entered coursework, cannot be edited once your application has been submitted.

How do I choose which dental schools to apply to?

Consider each school's prerequisite requirements, academic expectations, mission, curriculum, clinical training opportunities, location, class size, and tuition costs. Apply to schools where your academic profile and experiences are a good fit, rather than selecting programs based solely on rankings. Students are encouraged to meet with HPA to develop a school list.

What makes a strong personal statement?

A strong personal statement clearly explains your motivation for pursuing dentistry while demonstrating thoughtful reflection on the experiences that shaped your decision. Rather than

repeating your résumé, focus on telling an authentic story that highlights your personal growth, values, and readiness for the profession.

Can I reuse letters of recommendation from a previous application cycle?

Yes. If you are going through the Villanova HPA letter packet process during your reapplication, we can submit your old letters of recommendation on your behalf. However, *one new letter of recommendation is required* for reapplicants.

What if one of my recommenders submits their letter late?

You may submit your ADEA AADSAS application before all letters are received. However, many dental schools will not review your application until all required letters have been submitted, so request letters early and monitor their status throughout the application cycle.

Do I need to complete supplemental applications?

Usually, yes. Many dental schools require supplemental applications, additional essays, or application fees after receiving your ADEA AADSAS application. Monitor your email regularly and complete supplemental requirements promptly, as your application may not be reviewed until they are received.

Gap Years & Academic Enhancement FAQ

Will taking a gap year hurt my chances of admission?

No. Many successful applicants take one or more gap years before dental school to gain additional experience, strengthen their application, or ensure they are fully prepared for the demands of dental school. What matters most is how you use that time and whether it demonstrates continued personal and professional growth.

Should I complete a post-baccalaureate program or an SMP?

It depends on your individual academic record and application goals. Post-baccalaureate programs are generally intended to improve undergraduate academic performance or complete prerequisite coursework, while Specialized Master's Programs (SMPs) are designed for applicants who need to demonstrate success in rigorous graduate-level biomedical science coursework. Meet with HPA before pursuing either option to determine which, if any, is appropriate for your situation.

What should I do during a gap year?

Your gap year should reflect what you need to accomplish before applying. Common activities include working in a dental or healthcare setting, expanding shadowing experiences, participating in community service, conducting research, preparing for or retaking the DAT, or strengthening your academic record. Choose experiences that align with your goals and help prepare you for dental school.

How do I know if academic enhancement is right for me?

Academic enhancement may be appropriate if your academic record does not accurately reflect your ability to succeed in dental school. Before enrolling in additional coursework or graduate programs, meet with HPA to review your academic performance, DAT scores, and overall competitiveness. Together, you can determine whether academic enhancement – or another strategy – is the most effective way to strengthen your application.

What if I'm still not sure what path is right for me?

You don't have to navigate this journey alone. Health Professions Advising is here to support you from career exploration through the application process. Whether you're deciding if dentistry is the right fit, planning for dental school prerequisites, strengthening your application, or preparing to apply, schedule an appointment with HPA. We are committed to helping you develop an individualized plan that aligns with your goals and supports your success.

In Conclusion

Preparing for dental school requires strong academic preparation, meaningful exposure to the profession, service, reflection, and continued personal and professional growth.

Successful dental school applicants follow many different academic and application timelines. Strong preparation includes academic readiness, informed exploration of the profession, sustained experiences, and an understanding of why dentistry is the right career for you.

This handbook is intended to provide a foundation for that journey, but it is not a substitute for individualized advising. Admissions requirements evolve, application timelines change, and every student's circumstances are different. Throughout your time at Villanova, and even after graduation, the Health Professions Advising Program is here to help you navigate each stage of the process. Whether you are exploring dentistry for the first time, planning for dental school prerequisites, preparing for the DAT, applying to dental school, or considering a gap year, we encourage you to seek guidance early and often.

We are excited to support you as you pursue your goals and look forward to working with you throughout your journey to becoming a dentist.

Best wishes for continued success,

The Villanova University Health Professions Advising Program